

TASK 7: Phishing Indicator Checklist

Phishing Email Analysis

Phishing is a social engineering technique in which attackers send fraudulent emails or messages that appear to come from a trusted person or organization. The goal is usually to trick the recipient into revealing sensitive information, clicking a malicious link, opening an attachment, or performing an unsafe action.

Phishing Indicator Checklist

1. Sender Address

Check whether the sender's email address belongs to the legitimate organization.

Warning signs:

- Slightly misspelled domain names.
- Unexpected sender addresses.
- Free email accounts pretending to represent organizations.
- Differences between the displayed sender name and actual email address.

Action: Verify the sender through an official contact method before responding.

2. Urgent or Threatening Language

Phishing emails often create a sense of urgency or fear to make the recipient act without thinking.

Examples:

- "Your account will be closed today."
- "Immediate action required."
- "Your payment has failed."
- "You must verify your account now."

Action: Don't rush. Verify the request independently.

3. Suspicious Links

Check links carefully before clicking them.

Warning signs:

- The displayed link and actual destination do not match.
- Strange or misspelled domains.
- Shortened URLs from unknown sources.
- Links asking you to log in unexpectedly.

Action: Instead of clicking the email link, manually open the organization's official website or use its official application.

4. Unexpected Attachments

Unexpected attachments can contain malicious content.

Warning signs:

- Attachments you were not expecting.
- Files with suspicious names or extensions.
- Messages pressuring you to open an attachment immediately.

Action: Do not open unexpected attachments. Confirm with the sender through a trusted channel.

5. Requests for Sensitive Information

Legitimate organizations generally should not unexpectedly ask you to provide passwords, OTPs, PINs, or other sensitive credentials through email.

Warning signs:

- Requests for passwords.

- Requests for OTPs or authentication codes.
- Requests for banking information.
- Requests for identity documents.

Action: Never share passwords or authentication codes through email.

6. Poor Grammar and Formatting

Some phishing emails contain spelling mistakes, unusual grammar, inconsistent formatting, or strange wording.

Action: Treat unusual language as a warning sign, especially when combined with suspicious links or urgent requests.

7. Suspicious Requests

Be cautious when an email asks you to:

- Transfer money.
- Purchase gift cards.
- Change payment details.
- Share confidential files.
- Install unknown software.
- Bypass normal security procedures.

Action: Verify unusual requests through a separate trusted communication channel.

8. Personalization

Some phishing emails are generic and use greetings such as "Dear Customer."

However, sophisticated phishing attacks can contain accurate personal information. Therefore, personalization alone does not prove that an email is legitimate.

Action: Evaluate the sender, links, request, and context together.

Quick Phishing Checklist

Before interacting with an unexpected email, ask:

- ☐ Do I recognize the sender?
- ☐ Is the sender's actual email address legitimate?
- ☐ Was I expecting this message?
- ☐ Is the email creating unnecessary urgency?
- ☐ Does it contain a suspicious link?
- ☐ Does the link lead to the expected website?
- ☐ Does it contain an unexpected attachment?
- ☐ Is it asking for a password, OTP, or sensitive information?
- ☐ Is it requesting money or an unusual action?
- ☐ Does the message contain suspicious grammar or formatting?
- ☐ Can I verify the request through an official channel?

What to Do If an Email Looks Suspicious

1. Do not click suspicious links.
2. Do not open unexpected attachments.
3. Do not reply with sensitive information.
4. Verify the request through an official website or trusted contact.
5. Report the email to the organization's security or IT team.
6. Delete or quarantine the message after reporting it, according to organizational policy.